



Theosis: Becoming Partakers of the Divine Nature

Level V (High School & College) · By Dn. Yonnas · Debre Nazreth St. Mary & St. Gabriel EOTC

MEMORY VERSE · 2 PETER 1:4

“...that through these you may be partakers of the divine nature.”

Central message: God became man so that man might become god — not by sharing God’s essence, but by grace: united to Christ, filled with the Holy Spirit, and restored to the image of God. This is the very heart of salvation in our Church.

Key Points

- **Theosis** (deification) means **partaking of the divine nature by grace** — becoming by grace what God is by nature: holy, immortal, full of light.
- **The Golden Exchange** (St. Athanasius): “He was made man that we might be made God.”
- Grounded in Scripture — 2 Peter 1:4; John 1:12; Romans 8:29; 1 John 3:2; John 17:21–23 — and in our Alexandrian Fathers: Irenaeus, Athanasius, Cyril.
- **The guardrail:** we are united to God **by grace, never by essence**; the Creator–creature distinction remains forever.
- **Iron in the fire:** the iron glows with the fire’s heat and light yet never stops being iron — the soul is filled with God yet remains a creature.
- **How it happens:** new birth in **Baptism & Chrismation**, real union in the **Eucharist**, and the daily struggle of prayer, fasting, and love — grace working with our effort (**synergy**).
- **Ethiopian connection:** St. Athanasius, the teacher of theosis, consecrated St. Frumentius (Abba Selama) as Ethiopia’s first bishop — our Church has taught theosis from its first bishop.
- Theosis begins now and is **completed in the age to come**, when we share Christ’s incorruptibility and glory as glorified creatures.

Key Terms

Theosis / Deification

Partaking of the divine nature by grace; union with God and growth into His likeness.

The Golden Exchange

“God became man that man might become god” (St. Athanasius).

By grace, not by essence

United to God truly, yet never becoming God by nature.

Synergy

The cooperation of God’s grace with our free effort.

Image and likeness

The image restored; the likeness (Christlikeness) attained.

Review Questions

1. Why is “getting to heaven” too small a definition of salvation? What is the bigger goal?
2. How does the Incarnation make theosis possible, and why does our confession of Christ matter?
3. What is the difference between being god *by grace* and God *by essence* — and why does it matter?
4. Explain the iron-in-the-fire picture in your own words.
5. Name two Mysteries through which theosis works, and one daily practice that is part of the path.

Sources: Holy Scripture (2 Peter 1:4; John 1:12; 17:21–23; Romans 8:29; 1 John 3:2; John 6:56; Genesis 1:26) · St. Athanasius, *On the Incarnation* §54 · St. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* V · St. Cyril of Alexandria, *Commentary on John; Fragment on Psalm 82* · Coptic/Oriental Orthodox liturgical tradition. Doctrinal questions belong to your father confessor or parish priest.